01 / AUDIT THE REASON TO WRITE

Cold Email Teardown Checklist

Find the reason to write. Remove the claims you cannot support. Make the next step useful and easy to understand.

For early SDRs, BDRs, and job seekers. Work through the fictional example, then rewrite it on page 3. No real recipients, contact lists, or live sends needed.

1. Can you explain why this reader?

- [ ] **Connect the role to the issue.** What does this person own? Explain why your offer relates to that work. A shared hobby or generic compliment is not business relevance.
- [ ] **Check the evidence.** Open the original source. Record its date and what it actually says. A job posting is evidence of hiring, not proof of a broken process or budget.
- [ ] **Separate fact from hypothesis.** Use a question or conditional language for an unknown problem. If no relevant connection remains, do more research or stop.

One supported observation + source/date

Possible issue + what you do not know

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2. Does the draft earn the reader's attention honestly?

- [ ] **Use an accurate sender and subject.** Identify the sender and company. Match the subject to the message. No fake “Re:” or “Fwd:”, invented introductions, or implied prior conversation.
- [ ] **Keep one issue and one useful ask.** Explain a relevant capability in plain words. Ask for a specific, proportionate next step, not a call, referral, and download at once.
- [ ] **Remove unsupported proof and pressure.** Verify product claims, customer names, results, and deadlines. Never invent familiarity, urgency, or an outcome to make the email sound stronger.

> **Before any real outreach:** confirm your team's approval, contact restrictions, and applicable local rules. Public contact details do not automatically permit marketing. Keep personal data in approved systems; do not paste private prospect information into unapproved AI tools.

02 / WATCH THE EDIT HAPPEN

Same facts. Clearer email.

Fictional practice brief. All people, companies, sources, and capabilities below are invented for this exercise. No email was sent and no results are claimed.

Facts within the scenario: Mina leads onboarding at Cedar Bay IT. A sample careers post dated November 4 lists two onboarding-coordinator openings. Jules works at Relaypath, whose sample product brief describes task owners and due dates in a shared onboarding checklist. Jules has a one-page example ready to share.

Unknown: Cedar Bay's current process, whether handoffs are a problem, buying interest, and permission to contact Mina.

Before: identify the problems before reading the notes

FICTIONAL DRAFT WITH DELIBERATE ERRORS

From: Your onboarding team
Subject: Re: our chat

Hi Mina, I loved your recent interview. With your hiring surge, your handoffs must be a mess. Relaypath is the industry-leading platform that guarantees effortless onboarding. Can you book a demo tomorrow, review our deck, and introduce me to your boss? We need to move fast. Jules

After: supported facts, one possible issue, one ask

FICTIONAL BODY EXAMPLE, NOT READY TO SEND

From: Jules at Relaypath <jules@relaypath.example>
Subject: Onboarding handoff checklist

Hi Mina,

Your careers post lists two onboarding-coordinator openings. If keeping handoff ownership clear is on your radar, Relaypath gives each onboarding task a named owner and due date.

Would a one-page example of the handoff checklist be useful?

Jules
Relaypath

Reserved example address, not a real sender. A live version also needs the required disclosures, sender details, and a working opt-out process. See page 3.

1. **Identity:** replace a disguised sender and fake reply subject with a clear name and topic.
2. **Evidence:** remove the invented interview, “hiring surge,” and assumed broken process.
3. **Relevance:** connect a possible handoff issue to a capability in the brief. No guarantee.
4. **Ask:** offer one specific, available example. Remove the pile of requests and false urgency.

03 / REWRITE IT. REVIEW IT.

Make every sentence useful.

Use only the facts on page 2, or a clearly labeled fictional brief of your own. Write a fresh version. Keep your explanation separate from the email.

Reader + work they own

One possible issue + one useful ask

Accurate sender + subject

Your revised body

Use short paragraphs. Keep what the reader needs; there is no universal word quota.

Read it as the recipient, not the writer

- [ ] **Why me?** I can find the relevant reason without guessing or reading a company pitch.
- [ ] **How do you know?** Every factual claim has support. Unknown needs, systems, and results remain unknown.
- [ ] **What would I do next?** One clear ask fits the context. I can decline without guilt or pressure.
- [ ] **Does it sound human?** Read aloud and check a narrow screen. Verify names, role, links, and claims yourself, including anything suggested by AI. Ask a partner to explain the email back to you.

One change you made + why it helps the reader

> **A writing check is not clearance to send.** For real outreach, confirm local consent and privacy requirements with your team. For U.S. commercial email, check accurate headers/subject, required advertising disclosure, valid postal address, and a clear working opt-out. Follow the applicable rules and honor opt-outs promptly; do not evade a refusal through another channel. A reply-based opt-out works only if your team actually processes it.

Further reading: FTC: U.S. commercial email guide · ICO: UK business-to-business marketing (guidance under review when checked November 11, 2026). Original practice aid, not legal advice or a full compliance checklist. No promised reply rate or inbox placement. Save the before/after as labeled practice, not evidence of customer results.